



URL of this page: <https://medlineplus.gov/anemia.html>

Anemia

Also called: Iron poor blood

If you have anemia, your blood does not carry enough oxygen to the rest of your body. The most common cause of anemia is not having enough iron [<https://medlineplus.gov/iron.html>]. Your body needs iron to make hemoglobin. Hemoglobin is an iron-rich protein that gives the red color to blood. It carries oxygen from the lungs to the rest of the body.

Anemia has three main causes: blood loss, lack of red blood cell production, and high rates of red blood cell destruction.

Conditions that may lead to anemia include:

- Heavy periods
- Pregnancy
- Ulcers
- Colon polyps or colon cancer
- Inherited disorders
- A diet that does not have enough iron, folic acid [<https://medlineplus.gov/folicacid.html>] or vitamin B12 [<https://medlineplus.gov/bvitamins.html>]
- Blood disorders such as sickle cell anemia [<https://medlineplus.gov/sicklecelldisease.html>] and thalassemia [<https://medlineplus.gov/thalassemia.html>], or cancer
- Aplastic anemia [<https://medlineplus.gov/aplasticanemia.html>], a condition that can be inherited or acquired
- G6PD deficiency [<https://medlineplus.gov/g6pddeficiency.html>], a metabolic disorder

Anemia can make you feel tired, cold, dizzy, and irritable. You may be short of breath or have a headache.

Your doctor will diagnose anemia with a physical exam and blood tests. Treatment depends on the kind of anemia you have.

NIH: National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute

The information on this site should not be used as a substitute for professional medical care or advice. Contact a health care provider if you have questions about your health.

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